



Delaware County Budget Hearings September 20th 2023 Segment #1

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Rs6jqFbhkY4
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Municipal Meeting Summary Report: County Budget & Administrative Session

1. Pre-Meeting Hearings & Committee Work Sessions

This session was conducted as an ongoing budget work session; no separate statutory public hearings were held immediately prior to the call to order.

2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** The presiding officer called the continuation of the budget work session to order [00:15:20](#), focusing on budget adjustments, auditor reviews, mandated salaries, and health insurance figures.
- **Attendance:**
 - **Members Present:** Council members, including Bill, Ryan, Eugene, Jim, and the presiding officer.
 - **Other Officials Present:** Tanya (Auditor), Ben (Counsel/Attorney), Pam (Insurance/Administrative representative), Fred, and various department heads/speakers.

- **Members Absent:** Not explicitly detailed, though scheduling conflicts for upcoming conferences and training were noted.

3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** None recorded (continuation of a budget work session).
- **Approval of Minutes:** Not addressed during this session.

4. Substantive Business & Board Action

- **00:15:32 Auditor's Office Budget Review & Line Item Adjustments**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Tanya (Auditor)
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The auditor reviewed various updates, including a 2023 budget give-back (noted on page 11, line f-102 at \$7,500, though later placed in question pending confirmation), a 2024 court zoom account reduction to zero (\$3,100 savings confirmed by state coverage), and highway fund line-item swaps (equipment operator and truck driver adjustments on pages 72-75 offsetting each other with no net total change). C-navs were reported updated in Gateway (11th county in the state), and Q-Bridge increases came in lower than estimated (actual increase of \$101,566, which is \$42,364 lower than the original \$143,930 estimate).
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Informational review; integrated into overall budget tracking figures.
- **00:28:52 Court Administrator Mandated Salary & Court Order Resolution**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Ben (Attorney) / Bill / Presiding Officer
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Discussion centered on conflicting statutory authority regarding the setting of the court administrator's salary and a recent court order issued by the judges. Ben reported speaking with Presiding Judge Cannon and concluded that the council has statutory discretion to set the salary, though the judges reasonably disagreed. Bill reported on discussions with Judge Cannon resulting in a proposed compromise: if the council sets the court administrator's salary at \$75,000 for 2024 (a \$5,000 reduction from the ordered \$80,000, and an increase from the previous \$69,000 baseline), the judges agreed to rescind the court order. Council members discussed the costs and risks of litigation versus compromise.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Consensus reached by the council to adjust line a-128 to \$75,000 and proceed with the compromise contingent upon the judges rescinding the court order. (*Action recorded by voice/consensus alignment*).

- **[00:05:04 / 00:50:04] Insurance Renewal & Premium Adjustment**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Pam (Insurance representative)
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Pam presented final renewal numbers for county health insurance. Rather than a projected 10% increase, negotiations lowered the increase to 2% over 2023. This change yields a savings of \$248,600 against the 2024 requested budget. Pam noted that exploring an alternative traditional plan requested by the Commissioners would have required 25% employee participation and driven rates up significantly (10% to 17% for employees). The 2% increase preserves the current plan structure and avoids passing heavy costs to employees who received no across-the-board raises.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Accepted as a favorable administrative update resulting in a \$248,600 reduction to the commissioner's requested budget line 173 (lowering it from \$3,418,250 to \$3,169,169).
- **01:18:41 Dispatch / Communication Center Staffing & Salary Discussion**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Communications Director (Fred)
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Fred spoke during the forum/budget discussion advocating for a \$3,000 second-year raise for 29 dispatch employees, totaling \$87,000. He emphasized that the center is finally at full staff after an 18-month struggle, and failing to honor the planned second-year phase of raises risks losing trained staff and incurring high turnover and retraining costs (\$10,000 to \$15,000 per person). Council members acknowledged the critical nature of public safety staffing while weighing overall levy limits, cash operating balances, and uncertain future investment income.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** Fred (Communications Director) addressed the board.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Referred for further consideration during Monday's follow-up budget balancing session.

5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

No general public citizen forum or open public comment period from un-associated residents occurred during this meeting; discussion was strictly limited to board members, elected officials, and department heads participating in the budget work session.

6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:**
 - The auditor and council reviewed remaining budget figures, noting an estimated available playing room of approximately \$257,103 (factoring in levy limits, insurance savings, and court adjustments).

- A proposal was raised by Eugene to shift funds to cover local income tax (LIT) overages in the sheriff's pension fund (\$82,880 over budget).
 - Individual council members were assigned homework to review their books over the weekend.
 - **Next Meeting Scheduled:** Monday at 3:00 PM for final budget prioritization and reconciliation prior to adoption.
 - **Adjournment:** The meeting was recessed until Monday at 3:00 PM 01:31:52.
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